Cybercrime Case Study – Phishing

Case Title: The "Urgent Scholarship Verification" Phishing Attack

Target: University Students in India (2025-2026)

Incident Overview: In late 2025, a sophisticated phishing campaign targeted several universities across India, including students in technical institutions. I researched a specific instance where students received an email that appeared to be from the "National Scholarship Portal" or their university's financial aid office. The email used a high-pressure tactic, stating that due to a "documentation mismatch," the student's semester scholarship would be cancelled unless they "verified" their details within six hours.

Modus Operandi: The attackers used a spoofed email address that looked legitimate (e.g., admin@scholarship-gov-in.org instead of the official .gov.in). The email contained a "Verification Link" that directed victims to a cloned login page. This page was an exact replica of the student portal, complete with university logos. Once students entered their credentials and, in some cases, their Aadhaar numbers and bank OTPs for "identity confirmation," the attackers gained full access to their academic accounts and redirected their scholarship funds to fraudulent offshore accounts.

Impact and Prevention: The breach led to significant financial loss for dozens of students and compromised their personal identity data. This case highlights that phishing is no longer just about poorly written emails; attackers now use high-quality graphics and psychological "urgency" to bypass logical thinking. To prevent this, students must always check the actual domain name of the sender and never enter sensitive info like OTPs on a website reached via an email link. Instead, they should manually type the official portal URL into their browser.